

months to really see the fruits of your labor. Or you may be one of those really, really unlucky people that don't ever win anything. But I tend to think that those people just aren't entering all that often, or they give up after a month or two.

WHAT ABOUT TAXES?

Pay them. You should get a 1099 for any prizes valued over \$600. You should also be an honest person and figure the value (true fair market value) on your other winnings. Claim it as unearned income on your return, and pay up. It really is no big deal for most people. My trip to San Francisco cost me \$120 in taxes on a trip valued at over \$2,500. While this will all depend on your tax bracket, it is still a really awesome deal!

I HATE SWEEPERS. THEY'RE JUST GREEDY PEOPLE LOOKING TO GET STUFF FOR FREE.

I'm sorry you feel that way. I love getting stuff for free, and that is my

main motivation for entering. But most companies love sweepers. Entering sweepstakes exposes me to thousands of new products and offerings that I may not have otherwise been aware of. By being a part of that marketing effort, I am 10 times more likely to buy something than if I had just seen an ad in a magazine. My opinion of the company is more favorable if they like "giving back" to the consumer. And I can't tell you how many products I have become brand-loyal to because the sponsor sent a small sample or a prize that I went on to love forever. Sweepstakes are marketing genius. And if you figure that the cost of these sweepstakes campaigns are figured into the cost of the product that we all buy anyway, shouldn't you get in on that sweet deal?

Sweeping can be a fun way to win prizes you can't afford to buy. If you're already spending two hours a day on Facebook or playing online games, just pop open that extra browser window and enter a few now and again. Who knows,—you just might be a winner! — **Linsey Knerl**